

Module 3 & 4



WHAT IS A GROUP?

- A group is defined as ‘two or more interacting and interdependent individuals who have come together to achieve particular objectives’.
- An individual will be unable to perform all the required activities, and group formation is inevitable to achieve organizational objectives. Groups may therefore be formed and accepted by an organization.
- Groupism may also be informal, that is, not recognised but functioning in the organization.
- Group dynamics is essentially used to increase the productivity and profitability of an organization and group behaviour is different from individual behaviour.

REASONS FOR GROUP FORMATION

Group formation has certain objectives. The purpose behind group formation may be task achievement, problem-solving, proximity or other socio-psychological requirements. Group formation is based on activities, interactions and sentiments.

- Task Accomplishment- The basic purpose of group formation is the achievement of certain objectives through task performance. Individuals come closer in order to understand the tasks and decide on the procedures of performance.
- Problem Solving- When people foresee or face certain problems, they unite to solve the problems.
- Proximity- People form groups because of proximity and attraction towards each other. The group formation theory is based on propinquity, which means that individuals affiliate because of spatial or geographical proximity
- Socio-psychological Factors- Sentiments and action-uniformities bring people closer. They also form groups for safety, security and social achievements.

STAGES OF GROUP FORMATION

The various stages of group development are forming, storming, norming, performing and adjourning

- The first stage is forming, wherein the group decides its own purpose, structure and leadership. Members decide what types of behaviour are acceptable. The membership is increased till the group is finally established. Individuals are brought together for the first time and a communication pattern is developed. The interdependence of members is decided as per the structure and goals of the group. They decide on plans of future action involving discussions on formulation of group goals and evaluating the resources for achieving the goals.
- The second stage of group development is storming, wherein members storm their views. They put forth their views forcibly with strength, and this evidences interpersonal conflicts. Many problems are brought to the group for discussion and solution. Many conflicting views may be expressed. Authorities and supervisors are frequently criticised for various reasons. However in an educated group, people consider the views of others with patience. They arrive at unanimous decisions with constructive attitudes. A group gets synergy if the storming stage is actively smoothened. On the contrary, the group will not advance if the members continue storming and conflicting with each other.

- The third stage of group development is norming, wherein members develop a close relationship and demonstrate cohesiveness. Members enjoy belonging to the group and develop synergy. A strong sense of group identity and a camaraderie is developed. The group structure is solidified and interpersonal relationships are developed with increased cohesiveness and sharing of ideas. It increases the positive behaviour and strong feeling of development among members.
- The fourth stage is the performing stage. The group performs its functions to achieve the desired objectives. It is fully functional and operational. This stage is directed towards the accomplishment of group goals. It explores the action to be taken and decides on innovations. Satisfactory performances and achievement of group goals are observed under this stage.
- The fifth stage is the adjourning stage of development when the group is dissolved. The adjournment stage is generally undertaken after completing the task, although the group may be adjourned even before completing the task, due to misunderstanding and storming. Mutual friendship is lost, depression is observed and the group is wrapped up with activities. Such adjournment is undesirable for both individuals and the organisation. The group objectives should be fulfilled before adjournment. Leaders play a great role in the continuation and adjournment of the group. Dynamic leaders always try to review and strengthen the group activities for the development of their people.

TYPES OF GROUPS

Groups can be either **formal or informal**.

Formal Groups- A formal group is set up by the organization to carry out work in support of the organization's goals. In formal groups, the behaviour that one should engage in are stipulated by and directed towards organizational goals.

(i) **Command group-** A command group comprises a manager and the employees who report to him or her. Thus, it is defined in terms of the organization's hierarchy. Membership in the group arises from each employee's position in the organizational chart.

(ii) **Task group-** A task group comprises employees who work together to complete a particular task or project. A task group's boundary is not limited to its immediate hierarchical superior. It can cross-command relationships. An employee's membership in the group arises from the responsibilities delegated to the employee—that is, the employee's responsibility to carry out particular activities. The task group may be temporary with an established life span, or it may be open ended.

Informal Groups- An organization's informal groups are groups that evolve to meet social or affiliation needs by bringing people together based on shared interests or friendship. Thus, informal groups are alliances that are neither formally structured nor organizationally determined. These groups are natural formations in the work environment that appear in response to the need for social contact. One simple explanation for such association is proximity. That likelihood is even greater when people share similar attitudes, personalities or economic status.

(i) **Friendship groups-** Groups often develop because the individual members have one or more common characteristics. These formations are known as friendship groups.

(ii) **Interest groups-** People who may or may not be aligned to common command or task groups may affiliate to attain a specific objective with which each is concerned. This is an interest group.

(iii) **Reference groups-** Sometimes, people use a group as a basis for comparison in making decisions or forming opinions. When a group is used in this way, it is called a reference group.

(iv) **Membership groups-** When a person belongs to a group (formal and informal groups to which employees actually belong) the group is called a membership group (or affiliation group) for that person. In a membership group, each member would be expected to contribute to the group's well-being and would enjoy the benefit arising from the group member's friendship.

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POWER AND POLITICAL BEHAVIOUR

POWER

- According to John K. Galbraith, power is defined as the ‘possibility of imposing one’s will on the behavior of others’.
- The essence of power is control over the behavior of others. Power is also a reflection of influence that one person may have over others.
- A person in an organizational setting can have power from two sources. These are:
 - Interpersonal sources and
 - Organizationally based structural sources

INTERPERSONAL SOURCES OF POWER

- ❖ John R.P. French and Bertram Raven have identified five general types of power which are based upon interpersonal relationships. These are:
 - Legitimate power: This is the power that is vested in the leadership to take certain actions.
 - Reward power: This power is the extent to which one person has control over rewards that are valued by another. The greater the perceived values of such rewards, the greater the power. These rewards can be extrinsic or intrinsic in nature with tangible or intangible values.
 - Coercive power: On the other end of the reward power is the coercive power which is the ability to influence punishment.
 - Expert power: It is the ability to control another person's behavior through the possession of knowledge and expertise that the other person needs and does not possess
 - Referent power: It is also known as charismatic power and is based upon the attraction exerted by one individual over another. It is more of a personal nature rather than a positional nature in the sense that this power is not designated or acquired because of a position but because of personal 'charisma' so that the 'followers' feel inclined to the 'leaders'.

STRUCTURAL AND SITUATIONAL SOURCES OF POWER

- Knowledge as power: All organization use information to operate. Thus individuals or groups who possess knowledge critical to the attainment of organizational goals and objectives have power
- Resources as powers: Resources are the backbone of organizations. They simply cannot survive without the adequate availability of all the necessary resources. These resources include capital, personnel, equipment, raw materials, customers and so on. Any person who can provide resources that are critical to the organization acquires such power
- Decision making as power: The authority to make decisions or the ability to influence the decision makers are both sources of power. The decision making power does not necessarily rest with the final decision maker. Even though the decision makers act, the real power may be with those who strongly influence the decision maker

POWER TACTICS

- Power tactics refer to the manner in which authority figures exercise their ability to control or influence others within an organization.
- They are often deployed to ensure compliance or enact changes in behavior or attitude in order to achieve specific organizational objectives.
- The use of power tactics in the business realm can have profound implications on both an individual and organizational level, affecting productivity, morale, and overall effectiveness within a workplace.

ELABORATING THE NINE POWER TACTICS

1. **Assertiveness** - Here, a direct and bold approach is employed to ensure others comply with the directive.
2. **Bargaining** - Involves direct negotiation and compromise to reach an agreement.
3. **Coalition** - This is about mobilizing support by having a group of people backing up an idea or action.
4. **Friendliness** - Making use of charm, praise, or flattery to win people over.
5. **Higher Authority** - Seeking the intervention or support of a higher ranking individual as a lever of influence.
6. **Reason** - Using logic and evidence to make a strong case for a decision or action.
7. **Rule and Procedure** - Stipulates adherence to established rules and protocols as a form of influence.
8. **Sanctions** - Punitive measures against non-compliance or rewards for adherence to directives.
9. **Symbolic protests** - Exhibits non-verbal forms of disagreement or resistance, such as work slowdowns, strike actions or boycotts, to impose influence.

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Political Activities

Meaning of Politics

- Politics has been defined by J. Pfeffer as ‘those activities taken within organizations to acquire, develop and use power and other resources to obtain ones preferred outcomes in a situation in which there is uncertainty or dissensus about choices’.
- Organizational politics involves actions by individuals or groups to acquire, develop, and use power and other resources to obtain desired outcomes in a situation where there is uncertainty or disagreement.
- Political behavior is typically self-serving and aimed at enhancing or protecting one's own interests or the interests of one's group.

TYPES OF POLITICAL ACTIVITIES

- **Networking:** Building relationships with influential individuals within and outside the organization to gain support and access to resources.
- **Coalition Building:** Forming alliances with others to combine power and influence to achieve common goals.
- **Lobbying:** Actively seeking to influence decision-makers to support a specific position or policy.
- **Controlling Information:** Selectively sharing or withholding information to shape perceptions and decisions.
- **Favoritism and Patronage:** Providing favors or rewards to others to gain their support and loyalty.
- **Impression Management:** Engaging in behaviors intended to create a favorable impression with others, particularly those in positions of power.

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO ORGANIZATIONAL POLITICS

- **Resource Scarcity:** Limited resources such as budgets, promotions, and opportunities can lead to competition and political behavior.
- **Ambiguity in Roles and Policies:** Unclear roles, responsibilities, and policies can create uncertainty and opportunities for political maneuvering.
- **Diverse Interests and Goals:** Differences in individual and group goals can lead to political activity as parties seek to advance their own interests.
- **Organizational Change:** Periods of change, such as mergers or restructuring, can increase political behavior as individuals try to protect or enhance their positions.

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE IMPACTS

Positive Impacts:

- **Innovation and Change:** Political activities can drive organizational change and innovation by challenging the status quo and promoting new ideas.
- **Conflict Resolution:** Politics can help manage and resolve conflicts by facilitating negotiation and compromise.
- **Career Advancement:** Savvy political behavior can help individuals advance their careers by building alliances and gaining visibility.

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE IMPACTS

Negative Impacts:

- **Reduced Morale:** Perceptions of unfairness and favoritism can lower employee morale and job satisfaction.
- **Decreased Trust:** Political maneuvering can erode trust among colleagues and between employees and management.
- **Inefficiency:** Time and energy spent on political activities can detract from productivity and organizational efficiency.
- **Increased Turnover:** High levels of organizational politics can lead to increased employee turnover as individuals seek more transparent and fair workplaces.

MANAGING ORGANIZATIONAL POLITICS

- **Promote Transparency:** Clear communication and transparent decision-making processes can reduce uncertainty and the need for political behavior.
- **Establish Clear Policies:** Well-defined roles, responsibilities, and policies can minimize ambiguity and the potential for political maneuvering.
- **Foster a Positive Culture:** Encouraging collaboration, fairness, and ethical behavior can mitigate negative political activities.
- **Develop Political Skills:** Training employees and leaders in political skills and ethical influence can help them navigate organizational politics constructively.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

While engaging in political activities, it is crucial to maintain ethical standards:

- **Fairness:** Ensuring that actions and decisions are fair and just.
- **Respect:** Treating others with respect and considering their interests.
- **Transparency:** Being open and honest in communications and actions.
- **Accountability:** Taking responsibility for one's actions and their impact on others.



Thank You